of the first Indian exchange bank in London in 1936. There was no indigenous institution dealing in foreign exchange business and Indian banking had long suffered from this disadvantage. It was Sorabji's aim to supply the deficiency. The Central Exchange Bank of India Ltd was established in London as a subsidiary and though it shut in 1943, it revived in a new avatar as a regular branch of the bank in 1954. Even here the difference between a pioneering trailblazer and the timid conservatism of the Board was in evidence.

The Board was inclined to advocate reasons against Sorabji's initiative. H.T. Parekh, a young college student in London awaiting his examination results, worked as Sorabji's secretary for a month. He called on him at Grosvenor House Hotel one morning to pay his respects and offer him his services since he had nothing else to do. Sorabji immediately put him to work, asking him to sort out the applications for the post of Manager of the proposed bank in London. Sorabji proved to be a hard taskmaster and Parekh recalled that he worked from 9 am to 6 pm without as much as a cup of tea. In all fairness to Sorabji, Parekh does not recall the former partaking of any refreshment either. Harsha Parekh, H.T. Parekh's niece recalls her uncle telling her that Sorabji was a very strict person and expected nothing less than perfection.[26] Parekh's testimony bears out the Board's negative attitude towards Sorabji's initiative and is best described in his own words: 'I had an old typewriter and with my one-finger typing, I typed the letter he then wrote to his Chairman Sir Phiroze Sethna. The letter I vividly remember was the one replying to his Chairman's letter asking him to return without opening the London branch. His characteristic reply was that every time the Central Bank of India did something new, it almost always got a negative response and rejected his Chairman's suggestion stating that his own reputation was more at stake than that of his Chairman.'[27]

Speaking at a meeting to mark Sorabji's birth centenary forty-five years later, Parekh observed that the Central Bank was the only important bank at the time which had no godfather but grew only with the support of the small man. He went on to compare Sorabji with A.P. Giannini, the founder of the Bank of America who developed the bank for 'the little fellow.' Giannini, he said, had to fight his way up against the established bankers of the East Coast in the same way as Sorabji had to struggle against the established banks. Both were innovative and unconventional, and shared the same